Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K ♥ A J ♦ Q J 10 2 ♣ A Q J 7 2	
♠ 9 6 5 3 ♥ 10 9 5 2 ♦ A 8 5 ♣ 10 9	N W E S	♠ Q J 10 8 4 ♥ 4 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ K 6 4 3
	♠ 7 2 ♥ K Q 8 7 6 3 ♦ K 9 4 ♣ 8 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♥
Pass	2NT	Pass	3♦
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♠Q

You were probably stunned when you picked up this hand and even more stunned when partner bid.

Your biggest problem is that partner has opened with a weak bid and won't credit you with such a huge hand. So you must make sure you don't make a bid he might pass until you're ready.

For example, suppose you made a jump shift to 4♣. Would partner know what that meant? Do you know what it meant?

The best(?) bid at this point is probably 2NT. Everybody knows what that means. Partner is forced to reply, and will either rebid his suit with a minimum hand or show a "feature" if his hand is better than minimum.

Partner replies 3♦.

Trust your partner. He has shown a better-than-minimum Weak-2 bid, probably 9-11 points, and a high card in ♦s, either the ♦A or ♦K.

With your hand you don't need anything else to make a slam. You have to decide between 6♥ and 6NT. Based on your reluctance to have an opening ♣ lead go through your ♣ A Q you choose 6NT.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♠Q.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♠Q.

Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 6? : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 9

The winner list isn't as bad as it looks, once you drive out the ♦A you'll have your three extra winners in ♦s.

In fact, your only real problem is making sure you get all 6 ♥ winners. If the ♥s split 3-2 it's easy, but if they are 4-1 you cannot afford to overtake the ♥J at the second trick. Fortunately dummy has both the ♦K and the ♦9.

Win the ♠A. Play ♥A and ♥J. East shows out on the second one. Lead your ♦2 to dummy's ♦9. Either you are in dummy now to run the ♥s, or West wins the trick with the ♦A. In this case you can win his return (don't finesse if he leads a ♣), and get to dummy with the ♦K to run the ♥s.

A 4-1 split isn't as likely as a 3-2 split.

But when you can

In this case dummy had a certain entry in the ♦ suit so you take advantage of that entry.

Board 2
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 7 3
♥ 5 4 3 2
♦ Q 4
♣ A K 10 8 3

♠ Q 6
♥ A
♦ A K J 9 6 5
♣ 9 7 5 2

♠ K 10 9 8 5 2
♥ 9 7
♦ 10 2
♣ Q J 4

♠ A J 4
♥ K Q J 10 8 6
♦ 8 7 3
♣ 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
2♦	2♥	2♠	Pass
Pass	3♥		
All Pass			

3♥ by South
Lead: ♦A

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 3 : ♣ 0 : Total = 6

With 11 points you would probably have bid 3♥, a limit raise, if East hadn't overcalled.

But you now doubt your ♦Q is worth 2 points so you just say 2♥.

Now West comes in with 2♠ and it is passed around to you.

With a known 9-card fit this hand is worth a 3♥ bid.

Everybody passes.

North would play 3♥.

South plays 3♥. West leads ♦A, ♦K, ♦J. East plays first the ♦10, then ♦2.

South plays 3♥. West leads ♦A, ♦K, ♦J. East plays first the ♦10, then ♦2.

Although there are two ♠ losers in your hand, one can either be ruffed in dummy or discarded on a high ♣. So you really only have one loser too many.

You should realize that if you ruff this ♦ with one of dummy's teensy ♥s it will be over-ruffed. East did signal a doubleton. The loss of the teensy ♥ doesn't worry you, you have plenty of them. But the loss of the opportunity to dump a loser should worry you a lot.

So don't ruff at all. Discard a ♠. Now you can ruff your other ♠ loser in dummy.

Be ever watchful for situations where you may be over-ruffed.

Often, like in this deal, you can discard a loser instead.

Board 3
North Deals
E-W Vul

♠ A Q 4
♥ A J 10
♦ A Q J 8
♣ K Q 6

♠ 10 8 6 5
♥ K 9 4 3
♦ 7 4
♣ 8 7 4

♠ K J 7 3
♥ Q 7 6 2
♦ 10 9 3
♣ 9 5

♠ 9 2
♥ 8 5
♦ K 6 5 2
♣ A J 10 3 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	3♣
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♦[2]
Pass	5NT[3]	Pass	6♦[4]
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace
3. asks for kings
4. 1 king

6NT by North
Lead: ♦10

With 9 points you have enough strength to make a positive response. And with a good 5-card suit you respond 3♣.

Partner says 4NT.

Partner's 4NT bid is clearly Blackwood. With one Ace you answer 5♦.

Partner says 5NT.

Partner's 5NT bid guarantees that your side has all the Aces, and asks for your Kings. With one King you answer 6♦.

Partner says 6NT and you pass.

South would play 6NT.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♦10.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♦10.

Winner count: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 4 : ♣ 5 : Total = 11

You need just one more winner. If the ♠K is with West then a simple finesse will provide it. This would not be a terrible plan - you can expect it to succeed 50% of the time. Of course that means you will go down the other 50% of the time.

The double finesse in ♥s is better. If West holds **EITHER** the ♥K **OR** the ♥Q you will succeed. This raises your chances to 75%.

So win the opening lead with dummy's ♦K. Play the ♥5, finessing your ♥10. East will probably win this with either ♥K or ♥Q. No matter. Win East's probable ♦ return and take 5 ♣ tricks, discarding your 2 ♠ losers. Lead dummy's ♥7 and finesse the ♥J. When this wins the rest of the tricks are yours.

Sometimes you will have two or three possible ways to try for a contract. You need to evaluate them as to which is the most likely to succeed. There are times when this can be very difficult to analyze, but fortunately some choices are pretty easy to make.

The choice between a single finesse and a double finesse is one that you will face many times. So remember that the double finesse works 75% of the time.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 3 ♥ 6 4 ♦ 10 6 ♣ K Q 10 8 7 3 2	
♠ J 9 5 2 ♥ K 8 7 3 ♦ A 7 5 2 ♣ 6	N W E S	♠ A Q 10 ♥ J 10 9 5 2 ♦ J 9 4 3 ♣ 5
	♠ K 7 6 4 ♥ A Q ♦ K Q 8 ♣ A J 9 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	5♣		
All Pass			

5♣ by South
Lead: ♦A

This is **NOT** a simple choice.

Partner may have a hand where 3NT is a laydown. Or he may have a hand where 3NT is a godown.

Science isn't going to help you so you guess that 5♣ probably has a good chance.

North would play 5♣.

South plays 5♣. West leads ♦A, then ♦2.

South plays 5♣. West leads ♦A, then ♦2.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 4

MAYBE East will have the ♠A and the ♥K. But maybe not. You do have an extra ♦ trick so you need to determine the best use you can make of that.

First pull trumps. It takes one round. Play your other ♦ winner and discard one of dummy's ♠s. This protects you from losing more than one ♠. Enter dummy with a trump and lead the last ♠. Assume East has the ♠A. If he goes up with it you will be able to dump dummy's ♥ loser on your ♠K. If he plays low you put on your ♠K and you no longer have a ♠ loser.

If it turns out West has the ♠A then your ♠ play didn't work. In that case you would enter dummy again and try the ♥ finesse. This plan is a winner if East holds **EITHER** the ♥K or the ♠A.

It's always nice to give yourself two chances.

With correct play you succeed when East holds the ♠A, but also if he holds the ♥K.

The key play was dumping the ♠ on your ♦K rather than a ♥.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 5 ♥ A K Q 7 6 4 ♦ Q 7 3 ♣ 8 5	
♠ Q J 10 7 ♥ J 9 3 ♦ A J 4 ♣ 9 7 2		♠ 9 3 2 ♥ 8 ♦ 10 9 6 5 2 ♣ A K Q J
	♠ K 8 6 4 ♥ 10 5 2 ♦ K 8 ♣ 10 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	2♥
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♣A

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣A, ♣K, ♣Q.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣A, ♣K, ♣Q.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 4

You must eliminate one ♦ loser, that means ruffing it in dummy. You would like to pull trumps first but you cannot chance pulling two rounds because if they don't split 2-2 you would have to leave one out until after you had ruffed the ♦. The problem would then be that the defender who took the ♦A might lead the third trump, preventing your ruff.

So first you must drive out the ♦A. After you ruff the ♣ you play a ♦ to dummy's ♦K. West takes the ♦A and leads a trump. You win in your hand, pull one more trump, then play ♦Q, ♦7, ruffing in dummy. Back to your hand with the ♠A, pull the last trump and claim.

As you see you couldn't afford to pull trumps until after the ♦ ruff.

And you couldn't get the ♦ ruff until after you had forced out the ♦A.

You have a straightforward 1♥ opening bid.

Partner responds 2♥.

With 17 points and two doubletons you are on the borderline between passing and bidding game. If partner has the top of his 6-10 points you want to be in game, if he is at the bottom you don't.

A reasonable bid would be 3♥, inviting partner to bid game with a maximum.

A better bid is 3♦, a Help Suit Game Try. This says the same thing, bid game with a maximum, but also says "Use your ♦ holding to help you decide."

That was just what South needed. He only had 7 points but decided the ♦ help was worth an extra point or two.

Board 6
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ A J 4 3 ♥ 4 ♦ K 7 3 2 ♣ A K 7 3	
♠ 8 5 ♥ K Q J 10 9 2 ♦ Q J 4 ♣ Q J	N W E S	♠ Q 10 9 ♥ 8 5 ♦ 10 9 8 6 ♣ 10 8 5 4
	♠ K 7 6 2 ♥ A 7 6 3 ♦ A 5 ♣ 9 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♥	Dbl	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♥K

When responding to partner's Takeout Double:- with 0-8 points you bid cheaply- with 9-11 points you jump in a suit- with 12 or more points you cue-bid their suit

You have 11 so you jump to 2♠. Partner bids 4♠ and you pass.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♥K.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♥K.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 3? : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5?

The loser count is somewhat misleading because obviously you can ruff some ♥s in dummy.

Sometimes it is better to count winners, even though it is a suit contract. Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 7

Thinking like this makes it clear that you must win 3 of your 4 small trumps. The best way to do this is to win the ♥A and pull 2 rounds of trumps with ♠A and ♠K, spurning the finesse. Trumps split 3-2, so leave the master trump out and cash your other high card winners. Then start cross-ruffing, ♥s in dummy and ♦s in your hand. The defender with the master trump is welcome to ruff with it whenever he wants - it won't stop you from coming to 10 tricks.

You may have been tempted to play the ♠K, then finesse West for the ♠Q.

If you tried that East would have won his ♠Q, then played another ♠. That would leave both you and dummy with only one trump each and you would have come up a trick short. You can afford to pull just two rounds of trumps, then must cross-ruff with your remaining four.